At Tezpur, the Dalai Lama boarded a train to Dehra Dun and continued by car to the hill station of Mussoorie on the western foothills of the Himalayas, where he met Nehru and other Indian dignitaries. A new place was chosen for the Tibetan leader, the much smaller hill station of McLeodganj in today's Himachal Pradesh, which has since 1960 also been the site for the Tibetan government in exile.

With the Dalai Lama and his entourage settled in India, the CIA could step up its support for the Tibetan resistance. The abandoned airstrip at Kurmitola north of Dhaka, which was built by the British during World War II, became the forward base for airdrops into Tibet and the place from which Tibetan resistance fighters were flown out to Okinawa, Clark Airbase in the Philippines, and the Pacific island of Saipan, the secret headquarters of the CIA's covert operations in the Asia-Pacific region. Nationalist Chinese, Korean, Lao, and Vietnamese commandos were already being trained there.

The secret Tibetan operation was codenamed ST CIRCUS and its aerial portion ST BARNUM. According to Conboy and Morison, because the planes would need to fly over Indian territory without permission, they had to factor in the radar at Kolkata. But the CIA had done their homework

> … and knew that the Indian system had no compensation feature and could be defeated if the B-17 used the Himalayan massif as a radar screen. Flying north over Sikkim, the crew would go as far as the Brahmaputra [in Tibet] for the first drop, cut east across the Tibetan plateau to Kham for the second drop, then veer southwest through Indian territory back to East Pakistan.[105]

To conceal American participation in the scheme, in case one of the planes was detected or shot down, the pilots were all anti-communist Poles who had been given asylum in the United States.

Muslim guerrillas in Xinjiang also benefited from the CIA's largesse, as did the Nationalist Communist soldiers in secret camps in northern Myanmar. A covert war on China was being launched, but, as Conboy and Morrison point out, 'the agency had taken great pains to exclude ROC [the Republic of China] from its Tibetan operations'.[106] And it is doubtful whether the USA was actually in favour of Tibetan independence; the limited scope of the operation seems to indicate that the main purpose was to annoy the Chinese and keep their armed forces occupied.